Chapter 6

Skills for Healthy Relationships

1. Foundations of a Healthy Relationship
2. Respecting Yourself and Others
3. Communicating Effectively

Lesson 1 — Foundations of a Healthy Relationship

Relationships in Your Life

One of our most basic human needs is to belong and feel loved. A **relationship** is a bond or connection you have with other people. Family members, friends, classmates, teachers, coworkers, neighbors — all of these connections shape your health in positive or negative ways.

Types of Relationships

- **Family** — Last a lifetime. Healthy family relationships support every side of the health triangle — physically, mentally, emotionally, and socially. Family instills the values and communication skills that carry into every other relationship in your life.
- **Friendship** — A significant relationship based on trust, caring, and consideration. Good friendships boost your self-esteem, give you a sense of belonging, and help you resist harmful behaviors.
- **Community** — Being part of a strong community positively affects every aspect of your health. Citizenship — the way you conduct yourself as a community member — means obeying laws, looking out for others, and contributing to making your community better.

Traits of Healthy Relationships

Mutual respect	You accept each other's opinions, tastes, and differences, even when you disagree
Caring	You show empathy and support, especially during difficult times

Honesty	You're open and truthful rather than hiding your thoughts or feelings
Commitment	You invest in the relationship and work through problems rather than walking away

The Three Cs of Healthy Relationships

- **Communication** — Expressing yourself clearly and understanding others in return — the foundation of every strong relationship
- **Cooperation** — Working together toward a common goal builds trust and shared accomplishment
- **Compromise** — Each person gives something up to reach a solution everyone can accept — but never compromise on core values or beliefs

Lesson 2 — Respecting Yourself and Others

Respect Starts with You

Self-respect is the foundation of every healthy relationship. When you value yourself, you naturally seek out people who treat you well and you're far less likely to be pushed into choices that go against your values or harm your health. Knowing your **values** — the beliefs and attitudes that guide the way you live — is essential.

Bullying and Cyberbullying

Bullying is deliberately harming or threatening someone who can't easily defend themselves. About **1 in 3 U.S. teens** report being bullied in the past year. **Cyberbullying** — using digital technology to harass, threaten, humiliate, or exclude — affects **26.5% of students** in the past 30 days and nearly **60% of teens** have experienced it at some point.

→ Tell a trusted adult — bring a friend for support if needed → Stick with a group of friends — bullies target people who are alone → Stand up for yourself calmly without escalating → Don't retaliate — fighting back usually makes things worse → Report it to a teacher, counselor, or through stopbullying.gov

> What makes cyberbullying especially harmful is that it doesn't stop when the school day ends. It follows you home, into your bedroom, and even into the middle of the night. If you're being cyberbullied, block the person, save evidence, and report it.

Tolerance and Prejudice

Sometimes disrespect comes from **prejudice** — an unfair opinion or judgment about a group of people. Prejudice often involves **stereotypes**, exaggerated or oversimplified beliefs about an entire group. **Tolerance** — the ability to accept others' differences — is the antidote.

Lesson 3 — Communicating Effectively

Three Communication Styles

Aggressive	Overly forceful, pushy, or hostile — doesn't consider others' thoughts, feelings, or needs
Passive	Unwilling or unable to express thoughts directly — goes along with others to avoid conflict, even at their own expense
Assertive	Expressing your views clearly and respectfully while also honoring others' perspectives — the most effective and healthy style

'I' Messages

A powerful communication tool is using **"I" messages** — statements that focus on your own feelings rather than blaming the other person.

Instead of...	"You never listen to me!"
Try...	"I feel unheard when I'm interrupted, and I'd really like to finish my thought."

Active Listening

- ✓ Don't interrupt — give the speaker your full, undivided attention
- ✓ Make eye contact — show that you're present and engaged
- ✓ Nod or respond briefly — small acknowledgments encourage the speaker
- ✓ Restate what you hear — paraphrase to confirm your understanding
- ✓ Ask questions — clarify meaning and show genuine interest
- ✓ Show empathy — let them know you understand, without judging

Digital communication tip: Before hitting send, ask yourself — would I say this to someone's face? Is this kind? Could this be misread? The same principles of assertive, respectful communication apply online as in person.

Chapter Vocabulary

Lesson 1

Relationship	A bond or connection you have with other people
Friendship	A significant relationship between two people based on trust, caring, and consideration
Citizenship	The way you conduct yourself as a member of your community
Role	The part you play in a relationship
Cooperation	Working together for the good of all
Compromise	A problem-solving method in which each person gives up something to reach a solution that satisfies everyone

Lesson 2

Prejudice	An unfair opinion or judgment of a particular group of people
Stereotype	An exaggerated or oversimplified belief about people who belong to a certain group
Tolerance	The ability to accept and appreciate others' differences
Bullying	Deliberately harming or threatening people who cannot easily defend themselves
Cyberbullying	Using digital technology such as social media, texts, or online gaming to harass, humiliate, threaten, or exclude someone
Hazing	Requiring others to perform humiliating or harmful tasks in order to join a group

Lesson 3

Aggressive	Overly forceful, pushy, or hostile in communication
Passive	Unwilling or unable to express thoughts and feelings in a direct or firm manner
Assertive	Expressing your views clearly and respectfully while honoring others' perspectives

"I" message	A statement that focuses on your own feelings rather than on someone else's behavior
Active listening	Paying close, genuine attention to what someone is saying and communicating
Body language	Nonverbal communication through gestures, facial expressions, behaviors, and posture